to call for a boycott of the survey. "I won't participate because I do not trust this government with my data," he said. The CM riposted that this exposed the BJP's "true colours", pointing out that its own ruling alliance in Bihar had carried out a caste-based survey. Even in Telangana, "BJP leaders did not utter a word of opposition", said Siddaramaiah, adding that the Centre too had now "initiated a caste census".

THE SPECTRE OF RELIGION

The BJP hasn't backed Surya's stand, but it has other discomfiting issues on its plate. For one, the All India Veershaiva Mahasabha, notwithstanding its distrust of the survey, has appealed to community members to specify their religion under the 'Others' column and not as 'Hindu'. Backwardness, and not religion, is the crux of the survey, but the Lingayat reassertion of an old demand for minority religion status puts the Karnataka BJP, which relies heavily on the community's support, in a fix.

Takeaways

- **Karnataka's socio-economic caste survey 2025 is under way. Has to cover 14 million households by October 7**
- **Unease among stakeholder groups. Three caste groups go to court, but HC refuses stay. Says participation is voluntary**

Meanwhile, the survey itself was stymied by technical glitches and resistance from teachers drafted in for enumeration work during festival season, prompting the CM to step in with a stern admonitory message. "Every single family in the state must be surveyed," he told district authorities in a video conference on September 26. Karnataka has set aside a whopping Rs 420 crore for the exercise, about two and a half-times the amount spent in 2015. Well spent? Time will tell. ■



MASTER PLANS SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at a press conference in Lucknow, Sept. 17

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

LAST MILE PUSH BY AKHILESH

The party goes hyperlocal—promising manifestos tailored to each district's needs and grievances

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

UTTAR PRADESH is larger than countries like Britain and Uganda, and its vast sprawl is often scantily clad in the arteries that bring an even flow of things from elsewhere, material or otherwise. Add to that the centralised ways of our administration, and you have a distance between Lucknow and the local universe that's far more than geographical. The Samajwadi Party has now come up with an innovation that may alter that with radical decentralisation—well, at least at the level of election campaigning.

Shedding the broad strokes of statewide promises, the SP